closed hearts of our (religious) leaders and scholars [have to] be opened so that the Musulmans should come to know who they are!… They only think of Muslims (i.e. themselves) as those who recite kalima, consume meat and perform sijda on the earth. (They should know) Muslims are those who wage war on their “self ” and control their desires and temper; and surrender (themselves) to the rule of law.’

In September 1579, in the midst of these discussions, an extraordinary document was drafted by Shaikh Mubarak and signed by an additional six of the leading ulema of the court including Abd un-Nabi, the hakim ul-mulk, and Abdullah Sultanpuri.* This decree, or mazhar, proclaimed Akbar to be the Padshah-i Islam and the Mujtahid of the Age. Through this declaration Akbar proclaimed for himself the role of interpreter of the law, thus freeing himself from the narrow confines of the sharia as practised by the ulema, and their distressingly limited understanding. Now, when disputes arose over religious points of law, it would be Akbar who would decide the issue and have the final say. However, it is clear that in the mazhar the emperor’s title as Padshah-i Islam, head of the orthodox Muslims, was sanctioned by the ulema, and not by divine providence, and Akbar only had the power to interpret Muslim law, not to create it. Moreover, every opinion Akbar proposed had to be in accordance with the Koran. He did not invent a new office for himself and in effect took over the functions and powers earlier vested in the sadr. The relatively pedestrian ambition of the mazhar can be gauged by Abu’l Fazl’s silence over it. Though it was drafted by his own father, Abu’lFazl gives it a cursory recording because, for him, Akbar would go on to reveal much grander claims as his luminous destiny ‘unveiled’ itself. The term ‘mujtahid’ that Akbar adopted was, however, particularly provocative. It was a term used for a scholar of Islamic law who used judgement, or ijtihad, to resolve finely balanced points of law that had no legal precedent. Yet Akbar, as he had openly declared, was illiterate. So Akbar’s impeccable knowledge, despite his illiteracy, was explained by Abu’l Fazl as being supreme and intuitive knowledge as opposed to the learning of ‘paper-worshipping scholiasts’.

In addition to the mazhar, Akbar also in this year decided to recite the khutba, the Friday prayers which usually included wishes for the reigning sovereign, himself. Faizi composed some verses for Akbar to recite from the pulpit: